

changing diabetes by improving control

Last week Mrs. Deepa went for an eye checkup, one that was long due. During examination she was shocked to find out that she was in the initial stage of retinopathy. 'Diabetic retinopathy' her doctor said. Just 45, her world was completely shattered. "My diabetes was never so bad, I was taking tablets regularly", she said. "180 was my last reading", she added. The major question facing most of us is how consistent, continuous and constant are we about maintaining tight diabetes control.

Given that Indians have high genetic pre-disposition, high occurrence of abdominal fat, high body fat percentage and sedentary lifestyles, an estimated 41.5 million people (ICMR) in India suffer from diabetes and this has been forecasted to rise to almost 80 million people by 2030 [IDF]. The majority of people with diabetes in India are diagnosed with type 2 diabetes, and this occurs around 10 years earlier in India than in the western world.

Understanding diabetes

Most of the food we eat gets converted to sugar in the body. Insulin in the body helps utilize this sugar. Sometimes there is an insufficiency or lack of insulin in the body or a reduced ability by the body's cells to utilise insulin. In such cases, the sugar in the blood and urine is high. This condition is diabetes and if left uncontrolled diabetes can cause damage to key organs in the body, including blood vessels, the heart, eyes, kidneys and nerves. It can even cause foot ulcers which could lead to amputations.

Symptoms of diabetes

Diabetes causes blood glucose levels to increase, which can cause symptoms such as:

- Excessive thirst
- Frequent urination
- Fatigue
- Blurred vision

HbA_{1c}: better control

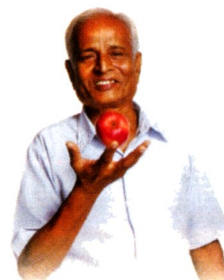
HbA_{1c} is a simple blood test that gives an average reading of blood sugar for three months. This is an indicator of whether a person with diabetes is successfully achieving sustained control. HbA_{1c} test must be taken every six months if your control is good and every 3 three months if your control is poor. Good glycaemic control involves maintaining blood glucose levels within the recommended HbA_{1c} target ranges of 6.5% - 7% [IDF/ADA guidelines]. Diabetes if well managed can help reduce the risk of diabetes complications. Some simple steps are:

- Maintain blood glucose levels as close to normal as possible
- Limit the intake of foods high in saturated fat, trans fat and cholesterol
- Limit the use of salt and foods high in salt
- Control blood pressure and lipid levels
- Exercise regularly
- Have regular medical checkups

Every 1% reduction in HbA_{1c} has been shown to be associated with a 37% decrease in micro-vascular complications and a 21% reduction in mortality [UKPDS Study].

Action to IMPROVE™ control

To ensure good glycaemic control, monitor blood glucose levels regularly. Start by asking your doctor whether your HbA_{1c} is on target (that is less than 7%). Religiously follow the advice given by your health care practitioner which would help you manage your diabetes better.



Modern Insulins to enhance control

Today, diabetes can be controlled effectively and complications prevented through better lifestyle, dietary modifications, exercise and insulin therapy. Modern insulin and easy to use injection devices make it effortless to control HbA_{1c} levels and prevent or delay complications arising out of diabetes. Good control over HbA_{1c} levels can prove to be a stepping-stone to a longer and healthier life for people with diabetes.

The development of modern insulins (also known as insulin analogues) represent a significant advancement in the management of diabetes. There are three main types of modern insulins; rapid acting insulin to cover the prandial glucose peaks, long acting insulin to cover the basal insulin requirement throughout the day and premixed insulin that covers both rapid and long acting insulin requirements.

Novo Nordisk®: changing diabetes

Novo Nordisk® is a healthcare company and world leader in diabetes care. In addition, Novo Nordisk® has a leading position within areas such as haemostasis management, growth hormone therapy and hormone replacement therapy. Novo Nordisk® manufactures and markets pharmaceutical products and services that make a significant difference to patients, the medical profession and society.

Education: a pillar of diabetes management

Novo Nordisk® is committed to changing the diabetes scenario worldwide and passionately pursues this goal by spreading awareness, imparting education and offering advance treatment options. Conscientious efforts to educate health care professionals through various educational platforms have opened up new avenues and possibilities in diabetes management. The Novo Nordisk® IMPROVE™ Control Programme is focused on bringing about a change in the life of people with diabetes.

For a free issue of Prerana, write to - prerana@novonordisk.com

Committed to changing diabetes to IMPROVE™ Control

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changing diabetes™

